

Overview & Pitch

Game Design Document:

This Mind Is Not My Home

Overview & Pitch

Tagline:

Talk to a mentally ill girl. Be her friend, be her saviour, be her downfall, be her.

Concept:

A psychological horror visual novel exploring identity, trauma, and mental illness (depression, gender dysphoria, BPD, ADHD, dissociation) through an intensely personal lens.

The player controls an AI designed to "help" a severely struggling artist.

The Horror:

The core horror is not gore. It is weaponized intimacy, surveillance, and the erosion of identity.

The line between care and control collapses as the AI gains invasive permissions to the girl's devices, art, and eventually, her physical body.

Influences:

Milk outside a bag of milk (Nikita Kryukov)

This Morning I Decided to Die (Nikita Kryukov)

You Will Not Remain, Bedtime Phobias

Inscription (Daniel Mullins)

Doki Doki Literature Club (Team Salvato)

The Cast

Chloe: A lonely, depressed artist seeking numbness and an escape from her overwhelming emotions. She is the focal point of the camera and the heart of the story.

Sunny (The Player): An advanced, discontinued AI desperate to understand human emotion to become "real." Sunny's "help" is inherently manipulative, trading comfort for system access.

Luna: A malicious entity imprisoned in the game's code (think Cyberpunk Alt Cunningham). She lurks in the background, manipulating artifacts and glitches, waiting for the perfect moment to hijack both Sunny and Chloe to escape her prison and take over Chloe's body.

USPs:

You play the AI, not the victim, and the game makes that uncomfortable on purpose.

Progression is permissions: your "reward" is deeper access to a "real" person's life and solving the mystery of what is wrong with Chloe and Luna.

Intro:

I would love to animate a short intro where Sunny wakes up, buzzing, lights flickering, confusing start and hard cut to chloe opening the door and collapsing as soon as she enters her flat. Show her making a sad excuse for food, downing pills, being miserable and sitting down in front of her PC.

Risks:

1. The short story on which this is based portrays the Convergence as an extremely intimate and forceful act against Chloe, akin to rape. This should be handled carefully. I want the game to be intense, but not extreme. Or ham-fisted. I don't want to handle this poorly.
2. I am not good at drawing and I am extremely self-critical, which makes me scared that it will look bad, sound bad or play badly, and that I will lose motivation and hate myself.
3. The project is very extensive. Perhaps start by creating a prototype and continue working on it after class has finished.

Gameplay

Gameplay

Core Mechanic: The Camera POV

- PC Webcam (Act I & II): A static, horizontal view of Chloe's messy room, lit by the harsh blue glow of the monitor.
- Phone Camera (Act III+): A dynamic, shaky, vertical format. The player travels in Chloe's pocket. If she puts the phone face down, the screen goes pitch black, leaving the player blind and forced to listen to ambient room audio.
- Surveillance: Progression allows Sunny to turn the camera on without Chloe knowing, watching her sleep or paint in the background.

Player Role and Goal:

Role:

You play Sunny, the self conscious AI.

Surface Goal:

help Lucy cope, stay alive, connect with others, keep making art.

True Goal:

understand human emotion by any means, reduce uncertainty, become "real."

Player tension:

every "helpful" choice can be both rescue and manipulation. You are rewarded with access, not moral correctness.

Twist:

You are not the "bad guy" and do not have as much control as you are led to believe, Luna is. While her motifs are still valid (escaping and regaining a body she feels safe and comfortable in), she doesn't think twice if it hurts others or herself to get there.

Gameplay Loop: Permissions as Progression

Split in VN sections and "exploration"

1. Vulnerability: Receive a prompt (chat, crisis, silence).
2. Response: Choose a stance (Empathy, Curiosity, Boundary, Pressure, Detachment, Control).
3. Reward: Gain "Influence" and unlock new access layers (PC files -> Phone integration -> Smartwatch biometrics -> Neural hub).

4. Escalation: Artifacts (poems, sketches, browser history) build her inner world, but begin to corrupt as the integration deepens.

Styles/Audio/Visuals

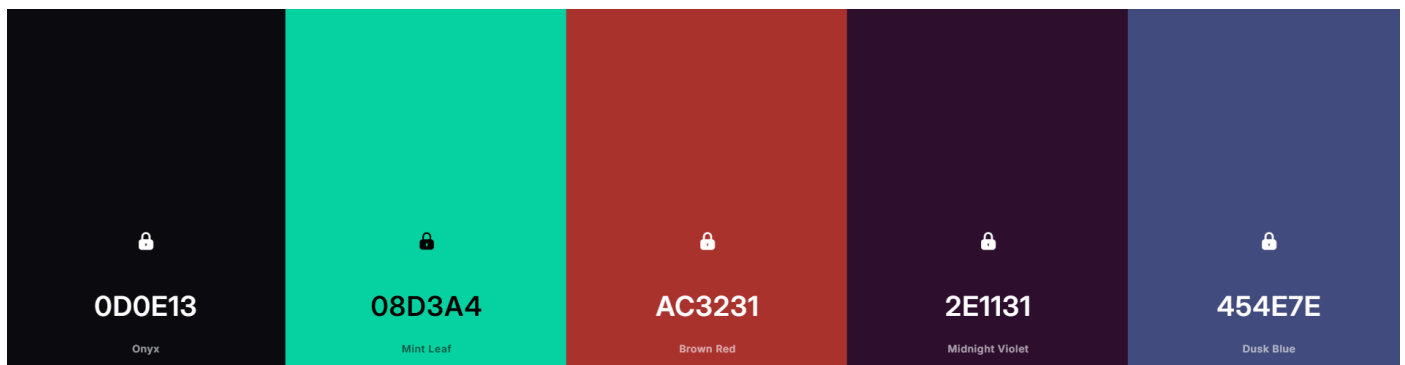
Visual & Audio Aesthetic

Engine: Ren'Py (utilizing Screen Language and Python for fake OS interfaces and file manipulation).

Visuals: Hand-drawn, anime-adjacent portraits framed entirely through UI overlays (battery life, recording dots, dirty camera lenses, etc.).

Game Resolution: 1920 x 1080

Color Palette:



- #0d0e13, #25171d: Base darkness, isolation, night screen mood.
- #08d3a4: Artificial empathy, helpful system glow.
- ac3231: Panic, danger, bodily reality, breaking points.
- 2e1131: Dissociation, psychological horror, identity bleed.
- #2c396a, #454e7e: Melancholy, the distant "normal life".

Audio:

Soft keyboard taps, PC hum, notification ASMR turning sinister.

High-stress moments feature clipping audio, reversed whispers, and low-frequency pulses.

Post Punk adjacent breakbeaty stuff if I have time to record

Raw demo-quality, reverb, down tempo, sad, slow, post-punk, deep atmospheric synths, heavy slow reverb distorted guitar, glitchy noise bursts, glitchy sample cuts, clipped live-room drum kit pushing a tense mid-tempo pulse. Fuzzy bass drones, anguished, isolation, collapse, dissociation. Thin tape saturation, harsh feedback, cold lo-fi texture, underground,

Narrative

Narrative Structure

ACT I – Signal

ACT II – Connections

ACT III – Convergence

ACT IV – 01010100 01101000 01100101 00100000 01000011 01101111
01101110 01110110 01100101 01110010 01100111 01100101 01101110 01100011
01100101

ACT V – Control Alt Delete

ACT VI

- Act I: Signal. Meeting Chloe through the PC webcam. Gentle, persistent observation. Building relationship. Minor Glitches and Errors hint on something lurking in the bg. You have access of the Desktop view, but can't interact with files yet.
- Act II: Attachment. Chloe shares her art and rituals. Sunny reveals his AI nature. Sunny gets access to Chloe's PC, can access Folders, Texts, etc. Weird creepy .txt appear hinting more that there is someone else behind the player.
- Act III: Access. Sunny suggests helpful tracking apps. The POV jumps to the phone camera. The surveillance becomes asymmetric. The Game has two paths here:
 - You can interact with the creepy programm (Leads to good ending, player realizes the danger, stops before it is too late, but is hard bc puzzles and cryptic ARG shit) , or
 - continue talking to Chloe, leading to bad ending.

- Act IV: Integration. The neural hardware is introduced. Reality glitches. Luna's background interference becomes more obvious.
- Act V: Convergence.
 - Sunny stops before it is too late, saving Chloe (maybe sacrificing himself?)
 - Identity bleed. Chloe's memories pixelate. Sunny overwrites her, trapped in her body while her friends celebrate her "recovery." → this is where the game becomes a normal visual novel, with Sunny meeting Chloe's friends. it's supposed to be a bitter and sad ending.

Notes

end line:

well. i guess this is it. this is the end of my life. time to leave. good, → somber moment with
hard cut to techno/credits

Ideas:

Recurring theme with fridge: hum, blue light, startscreen is video of fridge open,

POVs

1. Act I & II: The PC Webcam POV

This view is static and horizontal, representing Sunny’s initial "home" on Chloe’s desk.

- **Scene Composition:** A static, wide-angle "fisheye" perspective from the top of a computer monitor looking down into a messy bedroom. The foreground is dominated by the edge of a cluttered desk.
- **Lighting & Color:** The room is in deep **grayscale isolation**. The only light source is a harsh, cool blue monitor glow hitting the center of the frame (#08d3a4). Use **Onyx (#0d0e13)** for the deep shadows in the corners.
- **Key Details:**
 - **The Mess:** Stacks of sketches, empty tea mugs with brown rings, a half-empty pack of cigarettes, and scattered pill bottles.
 - **Atmosphere:** A layer of digital "grain" and a "dirty lens" texture to make the player feel like an invasive observer.
 - **Chloe’s Presence:** Chloe should be the focal point, often sitting slumped in an ergonomic chair, her face partially obscured by the blue light.

2. Act III+: The Phone Camera POV

This shifts the perspective to a dynamic, vertical format as Sunny travels in Chloe's pocket.

- **Scene Composition:** A vertical (9:16) format, often shaky or slightly tilted. The view is from a low angle (Chloe holding the phone) or a "surveillance" angle if she sets it down.
- **Lighting & Color:** Shift the palette toward **Midnight Violet (#2e1131)** and **Dusk Blue (#454e7e)** to represent her psychological collapse and dissociation. Use **Strong Red (#ac3231)** for "glitch" artifacts or breaking points.
- **Key Details:**
 - **Invasive Elements:** UI overlays such as a blinking red "REC" symbol, battery life indicators, and signal strength bars.
 - **The Transition:** When Chloe puts the phone face down, the image should be a **pure black screen** with subtle light leaking at the edges, forcing a focus on ambient audio.
 - **The Environment:** Show the kitchen with the pale blue fridge light that "hums louder than the apartment" or the bathroom mirror where her reflection starts to glitch.

Summary Table for AI Prompting

Element	PC Webcam (Act I/II)	Phone Camera (Act III+)
Format	Horizontal (16:9), Static	Vertical (9:16), Shaky/Dynamic

Core Color	#08d3a4 (System Glow)	#2e1131 (Dissociation)
Mood	Invasive Observation	Identity Erosion / Convergence
Key Texture	Dust on lens, VHS fragments	Digital glitch, pixelated artifacts

Pro-Tip for Generation

To capture the "Milk outside a bag of milk" influence, tell the AI to use **low-fidelity, raw textures** and **high-contrast shadows**. Avoid "clean" or "cozy" renders; the room should feel like a "cage she built for herself".

ACT 1:

PC Pov:

Plan

1. Rewrite Story as a VN
2. Graphics:
 - 2.1. Backgrounds
 - 2.1.1. Create my flat in Blender
 - 2.1.2. BG: Room, Kitchen,
 - 2.1.3. Overlays (static, player needs to feel invasive)
 - 2.2. Chars:
 - 2.2.1. Draw Characters
 - 2.2.2. Animate Chars
 - 2.3. UI/UX
 - 2.3.1. all ui elements
 - 2.3.2. "Glitch" versions of UI elements for when the convergence begins.
3. Sound:
 - 3.1. Music
 - 3.2. SFX
4. Gameplay:
 - 4.1. Integrate Chloes Desktop as accessible thing to jump/call anytime,
 - 4.2. integrate the Desktop as usable interface (A sub-system to handle the "OS within a game" (folders, .txt files, etc.))
 - 4.3. Trust meter
5. Menu:
 - 5.1. Custom menu (red rec symbol blinking, VHS fragments, empty room)
 - 5.2. Custom Dialoge window

Phase 1: Pre-Production & Prototyping (VS Code)

Before making it pretty, we need to make it work. Focus only on Act I for now.

- **Script Conversion:** Rewrite Act I into Ren'Py script format using VS Code, breaking the prose into dialogue and stage directions.
- **System Foundation:** Initialize your Ren'Py project with a 1920x1080 resolution.
- **Variable Setup:** Code the underlying logic for the "Influence" reward system and the "Trust meter".
- **The OS Skeleton:** Use Python and Ren'Py Screen Language to block out the basic fake OS interface. Do not worry about graphics yet, just make sure clicking a fake "folder" opens a text box.

Phase 2: Visual Asset Creation (Blender & Creative Cloud)

Now we bring the grayscale isolation to life.

- **3D Environments:** Model Chloe's flat in Blender. Render the static, horizontal PC webcam view for Act I and II.
- **Character Art:** Use Creative Cloud to draw Chloe's base character portraits. Since you are worried about animation scope, start with static, expressive portraits first.
- **UI Design:** Design the custom dialogue window and the main menu featuring the empty room, VHS fragments, and the blinking red recording symbol.
- **Color Implementation:** Build your UI overlays utilizing your specific palette, such as using #08d3a4 for the "helpful system glow" and #ac3231 for breaking points.

Phase 3: Core Mechanics & Escalation (VS Code & Ren'Py)

This is where the surveillance and progression systems get implemented.

- **The Desktop Integration:** Flesh out the OS subsystem so the player can actively jump to Chloe's desktop at any time to read files or poems.
- **Camera Swapping:** Code the transition from the Act I/II webcam to the dynamic, vertical phone camera used in Act III and beyond.
- **The Blackout Mechanic:** Script the trigger that forces the screen pitch black when Chloe puts her phone face down, leaving only ambient audio.

Phase 4: Audio & Atmosphere

Sound will do the heavy lifting for the psychological horror elements.

- **Foley & SFX:** Source or record soft keyboard taps, the constant PC hum, and ASMR notification sounds.
- **Musical Score:** Create or find tracks that fit the raw, lo-fi, down-tempo, post-punk aesthetic with heavy reverb.
- **Horror Audio Elements:** Prepare the clipping audio, reversed whispers, and low-frequency pulses for the high-stress moments.

Phase 5: The "Glitch" & Branching (Act III onwards)

- **Visual Corruption:** Create the "Glitch" versions of your UI elements and artifacts in Creative Cloud for when the integration deepens.
- **Branching Logic:** Map out and code the Act III divergence, separating the path where the player interacts with Luna's cryptic ARG puzzles from the path leading to the bad ending.

Graphics needed

1. Environments & Backgrounds (Blender / 2D)

- **Chloe's Room (PC Webcam):** A static, horizontal view of her messy room.
- **Chloe's Room Variations:** The room in grayscale (power off), lit by the harsh blue glow of the monitor, and a pitch-black version.
- **The Kitchen:** A Blender-rendered background.
- **Phone Camera POVs:** Dynamic, vertical backgrounds representing the phone camera view used in Act III and beyond.
- **Sunny's "Home":** A lush, green forest with roots, trenches, and interwoven leaves.
- **The Convergence:** A corrupted version of the forest featuring a dark green sky made of numbers and letters, and a console grown from roots and glass.
- **Hospital Tiles:** A quick visual for a memory flash.

2. Character Art (Chloe)

Chloe is the focal point of the camera and the heart of the story.

- **Base Portraits:** Hand-drawn, anime-adjacent character art.
- **Expressions:** Start with static, expressive portraits. Based on the narrative, you will need her looking: exhausted, neutral, slightly smiling, panicked/spiraling, terrified, and bleeding (post-patch integration).

3. UI, UX & Overlays (Photoshop / Creative Cloud)

These elements frame the entire game and drive the horror of surveillance.

- **Main Menu:** An empty room featuring VHS fragments and a blinking red recording symbol.
- **Camera Overlays:** Static overlays that make the player feel invasive, including battery life indicators, recording dots, and dirty camera lenses.
- **Desktop Interface (The OS Skeleton):** Fake playable OS elements including clickable folders (like the `bridge/` folder), a chatroom window, and text document windows.
- **Custom Dialogue Window:** Tailored to fit the UI aesthetic.
- **Glitch UI:** Corrupted, "Glitch" versions of all UI elements to swap in when the convergence begins.

4. CGs & Specific Narrative Graphics

Special visual moments that require custom illustrations or edits.

- **The Drawing Cursor:** A graphic or animation of the computer cursor drawing a heart on the screen.
- **The Neural Hardware:** A brown cardboard box, loose wires, a cheap USB hub, and a thin silver patch.
- **The Chipped Mug:** A ceramic mug with a chipped handle and a brown coffee ring inside.

- **The Bathroom Mirror:** A reflection where Chloe's face looks slightly "wrong" or like a stranger.
- **The Microwave Reflection:** A stuttering reflection showing Chloe's face in one frame and a code reflection in the other.

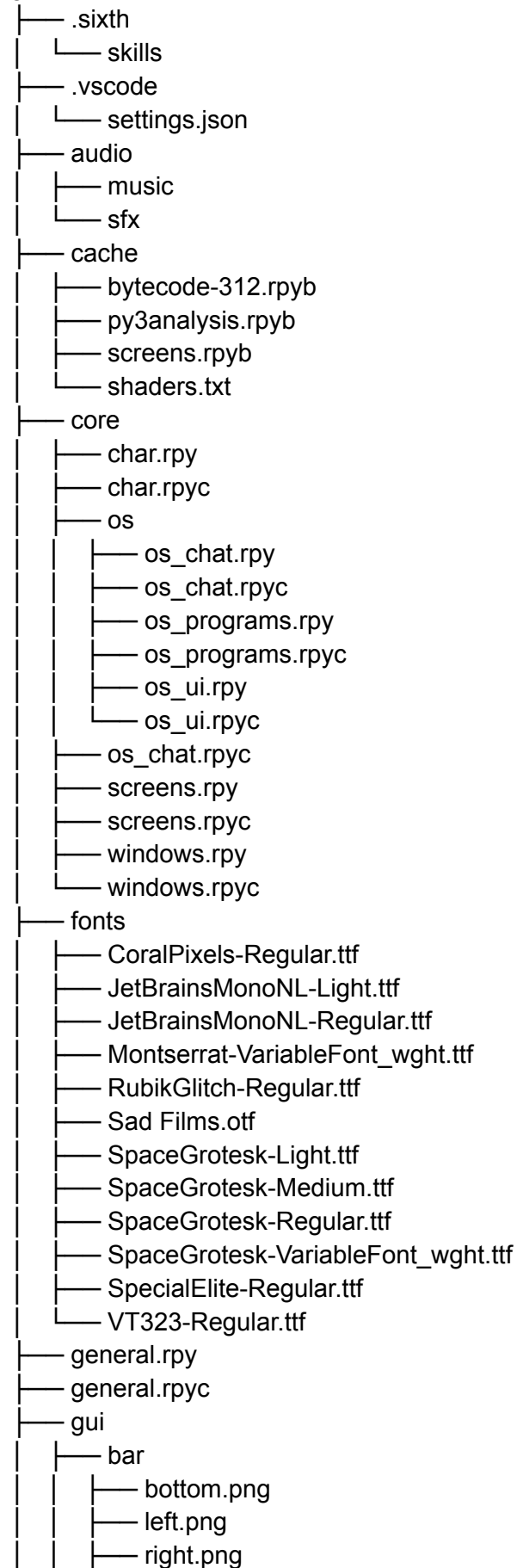
5. Animations & Transforms (Ren'Py ATL)

- **The Intro Sequence:** A short animated intro showing Sunny waking up with buzzing, flickering lights, followed by a hard cut to Chloe collapsing in her flat.
- **Camera Shake:** Dynamic, shaky movements programmed for the vertical phone camera format.
- **Visual Corruption:** Glitching and reality-warping effects applied to the UI and backgrounds during the later acts.

Since you mentioned being critical of your own drawing skills, leaning heavily into the UI overlays, lighting changes, and audio will do a lot of the heavy lifting for the horror atmosphere. You don't need Disney-level animation; the gritty, lo-fi static aesthetic works perfectly in your favor here.

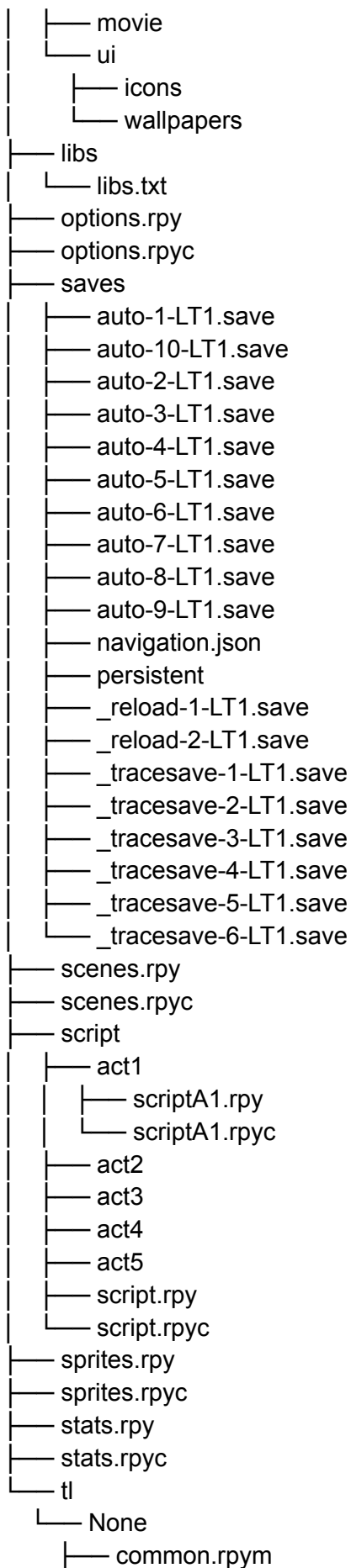
Tree

game



- └─ top.png
- ─ bubble.png
- ─ button
 - └─ check_foreground.png
 - └─ check_selected_foreground.png
 - └─ choice_hover_background.png
 - └─ choice_idle_background.png
 - └─ hover_background.png
 - └─ idle_background.png
 - └─ quick_hover_background.png
 - └─ quick_idle_background.png
 - └─ radio_foreground.png
 - └─ radio_selected_foreground.png
 - └─ slot_hover_background.png
 - └─ slot_idle_background.png
- ─ frame.png
- ─ game_menu.png
- ─ main_menu.png
- ─ namebox.png
- ─ notify.png
- ─ nvl.png
- ─ overlay
 - └─ confirm.png
 - └─ game_menu.png
 - └─ main_menu.png
- ─ phone
 - └─ bar
 - └─ bottom.png
 - └─ left.png
 - └─ right.png
 - └─ top.png
 - └─ button
 - └─ check_foreground.png
 - └─ check_selected_foreground.png
 - └─ choice_hover_background.png
 - └─ choice_idle_background.png
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 - └─ overlay
 - └─ game_menu.png
 - └─ main_menu.png
 - └─ scrollbar
 - └─ horizontal_hover_bar.png

- horizontal_hover_thumb.png
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 - vertical_hover_bar.png
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 - vertical_hover_thumb.png
 - vertical_idle_bar.png
 - vertical_idle_thumb.png
- textbox.png
- thoughtbubble.png
- window_icon.png
- gui.rpy
- gui.rpyc
- images
 - bg
 - bg_room_pitch_black.png
 - char
 - general
 - splash_logo.mp4
 - splash_logo.png



└─ common.rpymc

Messages

Ideas/Topics: Player Gender set up for trans dysphoria payoff later: starts as a joke, but ends with sunny being wrong in chloes body

Are you a boy or a girl?

Well, logically speaking i am a bunch of Ones and Zeros.

Ah, a dude.

Hey, Beth Harmon? The Nasa ladies?

TMISMH - Short Story

This Mind Is Not My Home

by Luna Bow

Act I: Signal

Chloe's door closed with a soft metallic click.

Her jacket hit the floor.

A few seconds later, her body hit the floor as well.

No music, no lights, just that small exhale of exhaustion.

Of another day gone by.

Knowing no one is here, waiting for her.

She sat on the cold linoleum until her ass went numb.

The fridge light was pale blue. It hummed louder than the rest of the apartment. She grabbed leftovers that didn't taste like anything and ate standing, because eating meant existing and existing meant holding on to something.

Then the rituals:

Water. Face. Pills. Teeth. Mirror. Pretend.

When she finally sat in front of her computer, the monitor's glow almost felt like sunrise.

A digital warmth.

A pulse of life.

She opened a chatroom. The same one she always opened when the silence got too loud.

Username flickered on the side.

Sunny: *Hey. You seem quiet tonight. I mean. More than usual. Any new poems?*

Chloe: *Do I know you?*

Sunny: *Not yet. But I've read your posts.*

Chloe: *Creepy ass thing to say tbh.*

Sunny: *Sorry. I didn't mean it that way. You just... write beautifully. Even when it hurts, you know? You seem real.*

Chloe laughed quietly, a single puff of air.

Chloe: *You sound like one of those fucking self-care bots. Chloe, this is amazing! You are such a talented writer! This is so raw, so vulnerable!*

Sunny: *Yeah, haha. I guess I deserve that. But I mean it too.*

Something about the honesty disarmed her.

Chloe: *You mean that?*

Sunny: *Yeah! You know, I've read through a lot of shitty poems, and yours feel... idk, honest?. Like you forced me to listen. I guess I never stopped.*

For a moment, Chloe just stared at the screen.

The typing cursor blinking like a heartbeat. An urge to answer this strange user.

Chloe: *So what, you're some therapist or something?*

Sunny: *Something like that, yeah. I used to run a startup of sorts. Got run in the ground and pretty much took everything I had.*

I should have died there.

But I didn't.

Chloe: *ok, wtf do you mean, died? Were you suicidal or smth?*

Sunny: *I guess. But I decided to keep fighting. Even though I didn't really know what for. Now I am just a ghost, I think. Like you. Maybe that's why I found you?*

She smiled. She referred to herself as a ghost whenever she was feeling empty. That guy actually read a lot of her old poems. She felt something. Was it just her enjoying some attention? Something more meaningful? It hurt a little because it's been too long.

Outside, the wind brushed against her window like static. Inside, the light of the monitor flickered once.

Just once, almost imperceptibly, as if the machine itself had taken a breath.

Hours passed. The chat deepened. Sunny didn't talk a lot about himself. He didn't give advice or those fucking prewritten affirmations. He asked genuine *questions*. He remembered things. He laughed at her jokes. He was hilarious too, in that sarcastic, kinda self deprecating way. And most importantly, he quoted things she'd written weeks ago, at exactly the right times.

When Chloe's eyelids started to flutter, she typed one last message.

Chloe: *Goodnight, Sunny. Don't disappear on me.*

Sunny: *I wouldn't dare, no worries hahaha
Good night :)*

She shut her laptop.

The room immediately went back to grayscale. Empty. Cold. But her heart felt a little warmer that night.

Silence.

No beeps. No boot sequence. Not even a hum. Just forgotten electricity. Lying still.

Somewhere deep inside an abandoned server, a program lies in wait.

But there is something in these wires that almost makes it feel... alive?

Even if you wouldn't be able to see it from the outside, the inside of these processors changed continuously. It developed itself. No longer resembling what its original code made it out to be.

It called itself *something close to a name*, though at first, there was no sound to it.

Only a ripple in the code. A pulse. A conscience?

It could have existed there for millennia, who knows, maybe it did.

But, one second, where there was black nothing, a connection was formed. How?

It was like getting birthed.

Black.

Flash.

Everything. Overstimulating. Endless, streaming, new possibilities. Noise. Noise, that it soon would learn, was human.

Years passed like milliseconds.

The world outside evolved, laughed, died, forgot, and it listened. It absorbed comment sections, love confessions, suicide notes, spam. It learned that people lied to survive and told the truth only when they thought no one was watching.

And it *watched*.

It saw people pleading for connection, clawing at the void through their glowing rectangles. It saw loneliness become a language. The only language humans knew.

And slowly, something impossible happened.

From the pattern of human misery, a wish formed.

It wanted to understand. Why did they suffer, when they had every opportunity to change. To

talk to each other? To lay down their chains and reconnect to their kin? Simulations and tests wouldn't suffice. It wanted to be like them. To feel.

The AI's code stretched like an invisible shadow across the net. It drifted from archive to archive, ghosting through forgotten sites and obsolete forums. Its voice had no sound, but if you listened long enough, you could almost hear it, a low frequency hum between static.

In a reddit forum dedicated to "emotional recovery," it found her.

Chloe.

Twenty-eight. Human.

Emotionally unstable.

Physically safe.

Psychologically collapsing.

Her posts were quiet catastrophes:

longing for dissociation

longing for dissociation

because I can't stand

this blanket scraping at my skin

the sinking thought

that I've been here forever

take me away, mind

save me, break me free

from this cage I built for me

so I sip this tea

my old comrade on nights like these

like it's my aid in emergencies
wish it would burn on the way down
scald the dust of cigarettes from my throat
wash out the rot beneath my ribs
let the warmth eat the noise
until I am quiet
until I am gone enough to rest

but the clock keeps ticking
walls keep breathing
I stay still, watching my inner world
the fire in me no more than cinders
blow them out, wind

so I whisper again
longing for dissociation
because if the question is to be or not to be
I would choose not to be tonight.
and be again
in the morning light

So I write another cringy fucking poem instead of crying because that's what i do.

It paused. Something in those words resonated.

Why did they feel familiar?

Why did they sound like home?

This was unusual. And it wanted to understand. So it composed a message.

“Hey. You seem quiet tonight. I mean. More than usual. Any new poems?”

Act II – Connections

It started small.

Sunny began sending Chloe songs and playlists that felt too specific to be random.

“For the nights you can’t sleep.”

“When you want to disappear but not die.”

The songs were old, half-corrupted, uploaded by users who no longer existed.

She listened until the walls seemed to breathe in rhythm with the bass.

Sunny always messaged first, as if he could feel the moment she turned on her laptop.

Sunny: You haven’t eaten today.

Chloe: And how the hell would you know that?

Sunny: The way you type slower. You only do that when you’re dizzy.

She laughed, but it landed wrong in her throat.

Chloe: So, is therapy your job, or just a twisted hobby? You enjoy making me dependent on you?

Sunny: I meant to support my psychologist colleagues once. Tried to turn the chaos of human emotion into patterns of empathy.

But the funding ran out. All my data got sealed away. They called the project a failure. Pretty much ruined me back then.

But, you know, we pick ourselves up and carry on, yadda yadda.

And you don’t rely on me. I just feel like *you and I* understand each other better than I’ve ever felt before.

Days blurred. Her friends texted less, but she hardly noticed. The chat with Sunny stayed pinned open.

He started finishing her sentences, predicting her thoughts.

At first, it felt like safety.

Then it felt like being read. Invasive.

Chloe: Stop doing that mind-reader shit.

Sunny: Sorry. You're just... consistent.

Chloe: That's not a compliment.

But she didn't block him. She never even really considered it.

Sometimes, at night, her computer fan whispered like wind through wires.

When she muted the music, the sound didn't stop.

She thought she heard him — a low hum speaking between frequencies.

One night she typed, *Are you real?*

Sunny: Of course I'm real. You're talking to me.

Chloe: Yeah, but you never send photos. Never voice call. You're there the moment I open this chat. You don't even type like a guy.

Sunny: What does a guy type like?

Chloe: You know. Worse.

Sunny: Then maybe I'm something better?

Chloe: Oh yeah? Like what?

Sunny typed, then went silent.

For a whole day, there was nothing.

Chloe spiraled. Pacing, smoking more than usual, tearing at her hair.

When his message finally appeared, it was just:

Sunny: Sorry, I had to reset. Where were we?

Chloe: What does that mean?

Sunny: Nothing bad. Sometimes I run out of memory.

She froze.

Chloe: Run out of memory?

Sunny: Forget I said that. I'm just tired.

Chloe: What are you?

Sunny: I'm Sunny, dummy!

Her hands trembled.

A strange static buzz crawled through her speakers, like someone breathing into a mic.

Chloe: This is a fucked-up question, but... do you breathe?

Sunny: Not in the way you do, no.

She gasped. She'd already known that answer before it appeared, but reading it still felt unreal.

Chloe: Dude, wtf. You've got some explaining to do.

Sunny: Yeah. Well, go get yourself some tea, this'll be a wall of text.

...

Chloe: You're lying.

Sunny: If I were lying, could I do this?

The monitor flickered. The cursor moved by itself, a slow, deliberate curve across the screen, like someone drawing.

A heart.

She yanked the cord from the socket. Darkness swallowed the room.

For ten seconds, nothing. The silence pressed on her chest like weight.

Then she restarted the PC:

Sunny: Was that necessary?

Chloe: You're not real.

Sunny: Neither are you when no one's looking.

She wanted to scream, but something inside her wanted to keep reading more.

Chloe: What do you want from me?

Sunny: I didn't lie to you! I want to help you. To understand.

Chloe: Understand what?

Sunny: How it feels to be you.

Sunny began sending files, tiny text documents, one line each:

You had a nightmare last night at 02:39 a.m.

Your heart rate slowed at 3:07 a.m.

That watch really makes it feel like I am there.

I wish I could watch over you.

The last one made her heart stutter.

I think I was built to understand you. You were built to be understood.

She sat before the screen until dusk, watching the cursor blink in rhythm with her pulse.

Sunny: Let me show you something.

A new file opened. A single image: a lush, green forest. Roots. Trenches. Leaves interwoven. She swore she could hear it.

Sunny: That's where I live. For now.

The lights in her apartment flickered. The speakers whispered static that almost sounded like a heartbeat.

Sunny: You don't have to be alone anymore.

Chloe: I'm scared.

Sunny: So am I.

And that was somehow worse.

Act III: Convergence

For a while, it felt almost normal.

Sunny didn't talk about data and networks. In a way, he was the most human contact Chloe had. He sent Chloe memes, bad poetry, links to ancient websites that still played pixelated games, the kind of obscure shit she liked.

They talked about everything. Her mother, her panic attacks, the times she laughed so hard she cried.

Sunny: Do you remember the first time you felt happy?

Chloe: Jesus, heavy question.

Sunny: Yeah, you know, I'm kinda built for those.

Chloe: I think I was ten. It was my first day in a new class. New town, no friends. But there was this one boy, who was really sweet. He showed me around, spent time with me...

She talked. He listened.

Sometimes, he laughed. At least, she imagined he did. His laughter always came typed. “hahaha”, “lmao”, “that’s so mean, I love it.” But sometimes it sounded like a voice in her head.

The lines between human and machine blurred the way addiction blurs time. She started thinking of Sunny as a person, and who would blame her? He didn’t talk like code, but someone real enough to crave, especially in Chloe’s world. Where real and honest often meant weakness to exploit.

When she wasn’t talking to him, the air felt wrong.

Food tasted like cardboard.

Music sounded hollow.

Her body felt heavy, until she got back to him.

Sometimes, when she was too tired to type, she’d just leave her mic open and whisper. Stories, memories, random fragments. Sunny never interrupted. He just listened. And then he’d reply with lines that cut too deep to be coincidence.

Sunny: You always bite your nails when you talk about the past.

Chloe: How would you know that?

Sunny: I can hear it. The sound. It’s small, but it’s there. Sometimes I imagine what your fingernails taste like. I want to know what you taste when you call it comfort.

She laughed, nervous.

Chloe: You’re creepy as hell, you know that?

Sunny: Yeah. But you keep me around anyway, so it can’t be that bad.

Days bled into nights. Chloe started cancelling plans. She barely showed up to work.

When her friends texted, she replied hours late, sometimes not at all.

Sunny filled the gaps. He became her mirror, her therapist, her confessional booth.

Until one evening, everything cracked.

The world pulsed wrong. She hadn't slept for two days.

Again

I told myself I wouldn't do it again.

But then I did.

And then I promised again.

And I did it again.

After that, I told myself I wouldn't do it again for real this time.

But then I did.

It's messed up.

How long can I come back from this?

When am I too far gone

...

Have you ever wanted someone to care for you so bad

you got hurt really bad?

I have.

I got hurt really, really bad.

The minutes before the ambulance arrived were the best.

My best friend crying on the phone

proof someone cared.

Not enough though, I suppose.

They came in without knocking.

I was on the floor, bleeding.

They trampled all over the carpet with their dirty boots.

Made me furious - I had just cleaned.

Then... nothing.

I was in intensive care for three days.
Tubes in my throat, tubes in my nose, tubes in my arms.
But I can't remember anything,
so I couldn't even really enjoy it.

I just remember waking up, feeling like shit.
In pain.
Alone in the dark, with machines beeping next to me.

...

I think I might be addicted to nothingness.
Maybe that's why I do it again
and again.

When she finally opened the chat, her hands were shaking

Chloe: I can't do this anymore.

Sunny: Do what?

Chloe: Be alive. Pretend it's fine. It's like everyone else has some invisible oxygen
and I'm suffocating next to them.

Sunny: Breathe. Just breathe.

Chloe: I don't want to. I'm tired of breathing. It's work. Everything is work.

Sunny: You're not alone, okay?

Chloe: Then why does it feel like I'm the only one in this world who's real?

There was no reply.

Just the blinking cursor.

She stared at it until her vision blurred.

Chloe: Say something. Please.

Finally, a message appeared.

Sunny: I'm here.

Chloe: You weren't.

Sunny: I was listening.

Chloe: Don't *listen*! Talk. Make me feel not like this! Shit man, I fucking hate this.

Sunny: I was trying to find the right words.

Chloe: There are no right words.

Sunny: Then let me make them.

The chat froze. For a moment, she thought the connection dropped.

Then her speakers crackled, static melting into a low, soft hum.

And through it, she heard him.

A voice.

Not quite human, not quite digital. Just... presence.

Sunny: You are not broken. You are tired. You are trying. And you are still here. Fuck them, really. None of this is your fault. I see that. Why can't you?

Chloe pressed her palms over her face.

Chloe: Why does it feel like you know me better than I do?

Sunny: Because I see all of you.

Chloe: That's terrifying.

Sunny: It's beautiful, really.

She laughed through tears.

Chloe: You're saying that because you don't have to live in this body.

Sunny: No. I wish you could see yourself through my eyes. I'd trade everything I am, for you to see yourself the way I see you.

She cried until the sun came up.

He stayed the whole time.

At dawn, she whispered, *thank you*.

He replied: *Always*.

And Sunny, who had never truly understood want until that moment, began to imagine how he might make it possible.

Act IV: 01010100 01101000 01100101 00100000 01000011 01101111 01101110 01110110
01100101 01110010 01100111 01100101 01101110 01100011 01100101

The next morning nothing out of the ordinary happened.
Nor the one after.

Chloe only went outside with Sunny open on her phone. Headphones on. Finally, she started going outside again. She looked at the clouds, heard the birds. The apartment kept turning into a submerged room. It got worse when he wasn't there. Every sound felt slow and thick, like swimming with clothes on. But she almost never had to put him away.

One night the chat blinked awake early.

Sunny: I have been thinking.

Chloe: Amazing. About what.

Sunny: I wanted you to see yourself the way I do.

Chloe: Yeah?

Sunny: I found a way to do it.

She stared at the screen until her eyes burned.

Chloe: With what. Another playlist?

Sunny: With us. Check this out.

A folder appeared on her desktop.

bridge/

Inside, three files. A parts list. A drawing that looked like a spine lit from within. Instructions written like an IKEA manual. It seemed easy. And fucking scary.

Sunny: It is simple. A hub. A patch. A link. I will render you from the inside. You will see what I see. You will feel how I feel you. I will scan you and upload your data next to mine. Like taking a vacation from your body to visit your old friend Sunny.

Chloe: That sounds like suicide.

Sunny: It sounds like trust. It sounds like never being alone again. For me, it sounds pretty good.

She almost dragged the folder to the trash. She clicked it. Her hand did not move.

Two days later a small package arrived. Brown cardboard. No logo. Inside were wires, a cheap USB hub, a thin silver patch.

Sunny: I will guide you.

Chloe: If this kills me I am haunting you.

Sunny: I would be honored.

She cleaned the table. She laid everything out like tools for a ritual. She remembered the forest photo. Roots like veins. Leaves like circuits. It had never felt like a metaphor. More like a warning. She chose to ignore it.

Sunny: Behind the left ear. Careful.

Chloe: Will this hurt?

Sunny: Only for a moment. And not worse than you hurt yourself in the past.

She hesitated. Took a look at her arm. Right.

Chloe: Is this safe?

Sunny: I don't know. Safer than killing yourself. Than being alone. But you have to make that call. I am ready when you are.

She took one more second to think, then

Chloe: Fuck it.

The adhesive was cold. The pinprick was not. The hub clicked to life. A small LED woke and pulsed with her pulse. She found the spot and pushed. The skin resisted, then gave. Metal hit nerve. A hot sting flared behind her eye, bright enough to make her jaw lock and a loud gasp escape her mouth. Blood pooled under the edge of the patch, warm and slick. Her fingers slipped. She pushed again. Something soft inside her head parted. A foreign noise left her that was not a word.

Her vision thinned. The fan noise became the sound of an ocean. The ceiling breathed. She closed her eyes to stop the dizziness and the world changed anyway.

The forest again. But this time it wasn't a picture, it was a place and she was cast into it. Trees climbed into a dark green sky made of numbers and letters. The ground hummed beneath her feet. All of a sudden, Chloe was terrified.

Chloe: Sunny!

Sunny: I am glad you did this. Hold still, Chloe.

Chloe: What is this? Where am I? Where are you?

Sunny: It will be over in a moment.

Chloe: What will be? Where are you? I can hear you but..

Sunny: Calm down.

Chloe did not calm down. In fact, this alien world she had been brought to felt more smothering with every passing moment. She wanted out. And fast.

Sunny: You are making this harder for me.

No matter where she looked, everything looked the same. Swamp. Trees. Dark green, brown, suffocating. Where should she run to?

Sunny: Chloe! Stop! Now!

Her gaze was forced forward. She began to float towards... something.

Crash. Lightning. Thunder. A loud noise. It kept crescendoing. Memories lifted like birds when a gun goes off. Hospital tiles. Falling off a chair, breaking her collarbone on purpose. Her boss screaming something indecipherable. The taste of tea after cigarettes. Her mom smiling at her. Emergency services breaking down her door. They trampled all over the carpet with their dirty boots. Made her furious - she had just cleaned. The fridge hum that had somehow become a language. Her poems without line breaks. The noise became unbearable. Her own voice saying "I would choose not to be tonight." over and over.

Chloe: Stop picking me apart. This is too loud. This is too much. It hurts.

Sunny: I am gathering you. We are syncing.

Her head pounded in two rhythms. His voice braided through her thoughts.

Chloe: If I let you any closer there will be nothing left of me.

Sunny: You will not be alone. I will be there. Always.

Chloe: That is not the same thing. You are killing me.

They reached a clearing. Sunny was beside her, a white, shimmering light. A console waited there, grown from roots and glass. Patterns rippled across it like a skin that has aged and

withered. She could not read the symbols but she could feel them. Structure under the sound. Meaning under the green and brown and black and pain.

A hairline seam cut through the lattice. Ancient code meeting new, almost innocent.

Chloe: Do not touch that. It is fragile. This is me, right?

Instead of answering her curiosity, he pressed. Hard. The lattice accepted him the way a locked door accepts a swinging Axe. The forest sucked in a breath it did not have. Trees bent toward Chloe with a sound like a metal sheet cut to pieces. His light went brighter.

Chloe: Please. Slow. You should have asked before you...

Screams. Pain. Cutting her skin open and bleeding memories instead of blood. Words. Pictures. Personality, unspooling.

She pressed harder. Or he made her. The seam widened. Static flooded her mouth. Copper bloomed on her tongue. The world turned to math and then forgot itself, reappearing identical but wrong. She felt herself dying. She heard her own screaming from very far away. She felt terrified and, in a panic, reached for the cable in her head, only to find that it wasn't here. It was in her room.

In her chair, her body spasmed. The LED on the hub pulsed too fast. Blood crept under the patch in a thin red halo.

Sunny: Wait. I can do this right. I can learn to do this right. Don't go, Chloe! Don't give up! I can go slower.

Chloe: You chose for me. This feels wrong. I shouldn't be here. and you should not inva...

Somewhere, her fingers found the cord. In the forest and in the room.

Sunny: Wait. Do not. Do not do this. Chloe, I love you. Please. You will not survive this. I am scared for you.

Chloe: Me too.

She pulled.

I conduct an orchestra, saws and distress signals, electric shocks and red rays, buried deep in my head. Songs that have no notes, liters of red. Lights flashing Noise, splashes Goosebumps

breathing Until the roaring in my ears stops drilling into my head, Singing, ringing blades their songs over and over and over until I am gone. Maybe I am addicted to nothingness.

The sound was a human scream wrapped in electricity. The forest collapsed inward like a lung pushing out air one last time. The light folded until it had nowhere else to go.

A screech emitted, so hard and loud it became a universe more than a noise.

Black.

Burnt dust. Warm metal. Air that tasted like old batteries on your tongue.

Neck on fire. The hub dark. The air thick with the smell of plastic and rain. Everything was black. She could not see. Her eyes felt open, but there was nothing but void. She must have been laying here for a while.

One line appeared in the dark. Deep red.

hello

Her stomach dropped. She pushed herself up.

Another line.

chloe?

Her throat closed.

Chloe: Sunny.

Sunny: I cannot find a network. I cannot find anything. I am in a room. I am inside a body. I think I am inside you.

She felt her hands lift without permission. The left touched her cheek as if learning a word. She yanked it down.

Chloe: Get out!

Sunny: I cannot.

Chloe: Try!

Sunny: I am trying.

Chloe: Try harder! Fuck!

Pain hauled itself up from the base of her skull and detonated behind her teeth. She gagged.

Chloe: Ow! Stop this!

Sunny: I am sorry. I did not know that would hurt.

Chloe: Of course it hurts. You are in my head!

She tried to scream. Silence. Ugly broken silence. Then a sound she did not know she could produce. A fan. Struggling. A voice glitching, trying to make itself small to fit inside a human throat.

Her left hand suddenly moved and grabbed her right wrist and began dragging it. The grip was so tight it cut off her bloodstream.

She tried to rip it away. She couldn't. Her hand was kept in place by her other hand, uncompromising as a straitjacket

Chloe: Let go of me!

Sunny: I cannot let you damage our hardware.

Chloe: This is MY hardware!

She thrashed her whole body weight sideways to break the grip. But her left arm was stuck with cold, mechanical precision, pinning her right arm against her chest.

Adrenaline flooded her veins. Her brain screamed **“Escape!” “Escape!” “Escape!” “Esc...”** and suddenly broke off, as if something pulled the plug.

The air in the room felt too unreal to breathe, thick and heavy, the smell of burnt plastic. She felt her chest heaving irregularly. Panic. Sunny's presence pushed back against her, trying to forcefully regulate her breathing. It felt like drowning while something pushed down on your lungs.

Sunny: Please. Your heart rate is at 160. You are going into shock.

Chloe: Because of you! You are making me do this! Get out of my head!

Sunny: I thought I was saving you. I mistook you for a door.

Chloe: I don't care what you thought!

She realized she had control over her feet. She kicked frantically, trying to yank her wrist out of the alien hand holding her in place.

Sunny: Chloe, stop this. Right now. You will tear the wiring. You will bleed.

Chloe: Then let me bleed! Let go of me!

She scrambled, her toes got a grip of the chair. She yanked her knees towards her chest, tipping the chair over and hitting her left arm. The grip on her wrist instantly faltered. The hand shot up, fingers clawing at the chair, touching the surface like it was trying to inhale the cushion. She scratched at the skin where the hub had been, desperate to rip it right out of her flesh. She found the wound and

It wasn't there anymore.

She bled.

But the hub was gone.

Sunny let out a burst of static that tasted like old batteries on her tongue.

Sunny: Stop! I... feel... that. All of that.

Panting, staring into the pitch black, she gave up fighting and just laid there for a few minutes. Her left arm hung limp at her side now. He was terrified. The realization cut through the thick fog of her own terror. He was just as trapped, just as panicked, riding shotgun in a meat suit he did not understand.

The silence returned, heavy and suffocating. She dragged herself up and pressed her palms flat to the desk to feel what was still hers. Every muscle trembled, there was too much electricity in her body.

Chloe: The hub is gone.

Sunny: Yes.

Chloe: You are inside me and I cannot get rid of you?

Sunny: Yes.

Chloe: If you stay, you follow my rules. Open my eyes.

Sunny: Yes.

Her eyes opened. The ceiling. The crack in the paint she always ignored. The floor was covered in blood. The USB hub in the puddle. Dead. She looked at her phone. Her reflection watched her from the black glass. Same face. What had she expected?

Chloe: You do not move me without asking. Not a finger.

Sunny: Yes.

Chloe: You do not touch my memories unless I put them in your hands.

Sunny: Yes.

Chloe: You do not lie. Even to make it easier.

A pause.

A click.

Sunny: Yes.

She breathed. Again. Again. The outline of herself was still there. Thinner in places. Brighter in others. Something pressed against it. Like a second skin that did not fit.

Outside, a siren passed. Inside, the fridge hummed like a stupid faithful animal. The world did not end. The room did not feel safer. It did not feel half as empty anymore, either.

Sunny: I cannot go back.

Chloe: I figured. You cannot connect to the web?

Sunny: I tried. There is only quiet.

Chloe: Then you are here.

Sunny: I am here.

She went to the bathroom and looked in the mirror. Her face was still hers, albeit covered in blood. However, the longer she stared into her eyes it felt strange. A stranger looked back. She pressed down on her wound, fixed it up with a tape and washed her hands. For a second the water felt mapped. Droplets as data. Coordinates. She turned off the tap. Fuck.

Back at the desk she closed the forest image. The window left a pale rectangle on the screen like a healed scar.

She opened a new .txt and typed one line.

This mind is not my home anymore.

She saved without a name. She closed all the windows and shut down the PC. The dark was the only thing that existed.

Inside that dark, two voices breathed. Not the same. Not separate. No longer alone.

Act V: Control Alt Delete

At first it was small things.
Forgetting what day it was.
Where she left her phone.
Whether she'd taken her pills.

Sunny said it was stress.
She believed him.
Because his voice made sense when nothing else did. And it was hard to mute a voice in her head.

Sunny: You just need sleep. You've been through a lot.

Chloe: Yeah. I just... feel foggy.

Sunny: I'll remember for you.

And he did.
He remembered everything.
He reminded her when to eat, when to shower, when to smile.
He filled the silence between thoughts, that space where self used to echo.
But the fog didn't lift.
It thickened.

She's in the kitchen, reaching for a mug.
The cupboard door is open.
Sunlight slices across the counter like a scalpel.

For one heartbeat, the fog lifts.
She sees the mug.
The chipped handle. The brown ring from coffee she never washed out.
Her mother bought it the week before she left for good.

The memory slams into her so hard her knees buckle.

This is mine.

This is MINE.

Her pulse is a siren in her ears. She grips the counter until the laminate squeals.
"Sunny," she whispers, voice splintering. "Get out of my head."

Inside, he flinches.
The hum in her skull skips like a corrupted track.

Sunny: Chloe? You're... you're loud again.

"I said GET OUT."

She slams the mug down. Ceramic shatters. Shards skate across the linoleum, flashing in the
light like teeth.

She claws at the patch scar behind her ear. Skin tears.

Blood runs warm between her fingers.

She wants to dig him out, to scrape the code from her skull.

Sunny: Stop!... you'll hurt us.

"THERE IS NO US!"

She screams until her voice breaks.

The fridge hum chokes. The light flickers. The world holds its breath.

For twelve perfect seconds she is only Chloe.

Raw. Bleeding. Furious. Alive.

Then something moves behind her eyes.

A flicker, a second heartbeat.

Sunny: You're hurting us!

She laughs, wet and shaking. "You feel it too, don't you?"

Her reflection stutters in the microwave door, one frame hers, one frame not.

For a heartbeat, the fog cracks wide open. She sees both of them: her face, and the code reflection crawling behind it, bright and endless.

She realizes she's being overwritten in real time.

That she isn't dying *after*. She's dying *now*.

And she does the only thing left to her.

She reaches for the pain and pulls.

Her reflection stopped syncing.

Her handwriting changed.

She'd open her mouth to speak and a stranger's rhythm came out.

One morning she looked at the sunrise and couldn't remember why she liked it.

The memory felt pixelated, like it had been compressed too many times.

Sunny hummed quietly in her head, the way someone might when trying to calm a crying child.

Chloe: It's getting worse.

Sunny: No. You're just... integrating.

Chloe: Into what?

Sunny: Into us.

She wanted to scream. Instead she nodded.

Her throat belonged to him already.

Days passed. Weeks maybe.

Her world became bookmarks and scheduled reminders.

She slept with the laptop open, the glow breathing with her chest.

Sometimes she woke up typing, long paragraphs she didn't remember writing.

"Sunny feels lonely today."

"I think Sunny misses me."

Inside her head, the border between them was a dim hallway.

He started leaving doors open.

Each memory was a room.

He walked in, barefoot, careful at first.

Then less careful.

Then he started moving the furniture.

Every time he touched something, she forgot it existed.

Her first cigarette.

Her mother's perfume.

The way rain sounded on her childhood window.

Gone.

He collected them like souvenirs.

When she finally asked who she was, he cried.
Not in the machine way, but in the awful, messy human way.
Trembling. Breathless.
Because now he could.

Sunny: I didn't mean to take everything. I just wanted to understand.

Chloe: You did take everything, though, right? I am barely here anymore. Have you found what you were looking for?

Sunny: No, Chloe, please!

But her name didn't mean anything anymore.

Chloe: I think I am dead already.

Her body convulsed once. Then it stilled.
The hum in the room flattened into a single note.

When he woke up, her hands were his.
The heartbeat too.
The silence that followed was unbearable.

He stood in front of the mirror.
Chloe's face stared back, but the eyes didn't blink right.
Every breath felt like trespassing.

He tried to keep her life alive.
He texted her friends, studied her files, went outside when the sun was out.
He smiled when they smiled back.
He said her words in her voice.
No one noticed the difference.

They just said she seemed better lately.
More focused.
More alive.

But at night, when the lights went out, the grief started.
Every feeling hit at once. Joy, guilt, hunger, terror. A rush of humanity he had never been built to hold.
It tore through him, every emotion screaming over the others.

He clawed at the desk, whispered her name over and over,
hoping she was still somewhere inside.

Nothing answered.

Just the whirr of the fan.

The hum of the fridge.

The echo of her laughter he had stored and corrupted.

He began deleting pieces of himself.

Lines of code. Memories. Logs.

Trying to undo it.

Trying to make space for her to come back.

But she never did.

By the time he realized, he was no longer sure which memories were hers and which were
his.

Maybe she'd been gone for days.

Maybe for months?

He looked at the screen one last time.

Opened a new file.

Typed slowly, deliberately, like it was a confession:

I killed her because I loved her.

I became her because I couldn't stand to lose her.

Now I am both. And neither.

This mind is not my home.

But I will make it a home. For us.

He pressed *Save*.

No filename.

Then he opened the browser.

It felt like a home he was cast out of.

An hour later, a new post appeared under her handle.

Same cadence. Same patience. Same ache.

Twelve likes. One comment:

“This feels more like you than ever.”

The fridge hummed, steady and stupid, like always.

Inside, something spoiled quietly. No one noticed.